Child Safeguarding Statement
St. Andrew's Presbyterian Church, Blackrock

1. Name of Service
St. Andrew's Presbyterian Church, Blackrock

2. Statement of Intent
This Child Safeguarding Statement has been developed in line with the requirements of the Children First Act 2015, Children First: National Guidance for the Protection and Welfare of Children, and Tusla's Child Safeguarding: A Guide for Policy, Procedure and Practice. It also gives effect to the PCI Safeguarding Procedures (Republic of Ireland).

St Andrew's Presbyterian Church, Blackrock acknowledges its duty of care to safeguard and promote the welfare of children, and is committed to safeguarding practice that reflects its statutory responsibilities, Government guidance and best practice. We recognise that the welfare and interests of every child are paramount in all circumstances.

The Kirk Session, minister, staff and volunteers of the congregation are committed to ensuring that all children have a positive and enjoyable experience in a safe and child-centred environment, and are protected from harm and the risk of harm while participating in the life and activities of the congregation. In line with the PCI Safeguarding Policy, we are committed to:

- Protecting children from all forms of harm
- Providing a safe, caring and supportive environment
- Ensuring all leaders and volunteers understand their responsibilities
- Responding appropriately to concerns or allegations

3. Nature of Service
St Andrew's Presbyterian Church, Blackrock provides worship, fellowship and community activities. The following activities and services involve children and young people under 18 years of age:

- Junior Church (Sunday School) for children and young people during the Sunday morning service
- Crèche during worship services
- Church social events (e.g. sports days, trips, outings, family fun days) and community/ecumenical events attended by children
- Use of church premises by external organisations providing activities for children (e.g. ballet, Irish dancing, toddler groups)

4. Risk Assessment

In accordance with Section 13 (Assessing and Managing Safeguarding Risk) of the PCI Safeguarding Procedures, the congregation has carried out a written assessment of any potential for harm to a child (as defined in the Children First Act 2015) while availing of our services and activities. The assessment identifies the areas of potential harm and the policies, procedures and practices in place to manage each risk.

Risk Identified	Procedures in Place to Manage Risk
Inadequate adult-to-child ratios	*Rotas in place; recruitment of additional vetted volunteers; commitment to maintaining appropriate supervision levels*
Lone working with a child	*Avoided where possible; encouragement of two-adult presence; visibility in rooms; doors left open where appropriate*
Open access building / uncontrolled entry	*Monitoring of access during activities; plans to install CCTV; leaders aware of responsibility to supervise entry/exit*
Toileting arrangements (no separate children's toilets)	*Parents remain responsible for toileting; leaders do not accompany children alone*
Children leaving before collection	*Parents expected to supervise and collect; leaders monitor dismissal; emphasis on clear handover*
Mixed-age activities	*Supervision by responsible adults; awareness of age-appropriate boundaries*
Photography and video recording of children,	*Photography and Video Policy in place; written parental/guardian consent obtained for official church photography where required*
Livestreaming services	*Care taken to avoid identifying children without consent*
External hall users working with children	*Requirement for safeguarding compliance; expectation of vetting and appropriate supervision; hiring agreements reflect safeguarding responsibilities*
Lack of safeguarding training awareness	*Commitment to regular training and refresher sessions for all our leaders*
Lack of clarity in reporting procedures	*Safeguarding procedures to be clearly communicated to all leaders*
Children attending church activities without parental consent or understanding of arrangements	*Leaders ensure parents/guardians understand the arrangements and agree before children participate.*
Harm to a child by the minister, a staff member, a volunteer/leader or a peer during activities	*PCI Safeguarding Procedures — Codes of Behaviour, recruitment & Garda vetting procedures*
Harm to a child from online abuse via social media or internet access	*PCI Safeguarding Procedures — good practice for online safety*

5. Procedures

Our Child Safeguarding Statement has been developed in line with the Children First Act 2015, Tusla guidance, and PCI Safeguarding Procedures. In addition to the risk assessment above, the following procedures — set out in full in the PCI Safeguarding Procedures (Republic of Ireland) — are in place at St Andrew's:

a. Management of Allegations
- Allegations or concerns regarding workers/volunteers (or against the minister, a staff member, a volunteer/leader or a peer) are managed in line with PCI safeguarding procedures
- Appropriate reporting to Tusla and cooperation with statutory authorities, including An Garda Síochána where appropriate

b. Recruitment and Selection
- Garda Vetting required for all relevant roles (under the National Vetting Bureau (Children and Vulnerable Persons) Acts 2012–2016)
- Application forms completed
- References sought where individuals are not well-known
- Informal or formal interviews are conducted as appropriate

c. Training and Awareness
- Safeguarding training provided for all leaders and volunteers
- Refresher training is expected every three years (with commitment to address current gaps)
- Leaders will be informed of how to recognise and respond to harm

d. Reporting Concerns
- Clear procedures for reporting concerns to Tusla and, where appropriate, An Garda Síochána
- All leaders will be informed of reporting responsibilities
- The Designated Liaison Person (DLP) is the key contact

e. Mandated Persons
- The Minister is a mandated person under the Children First Act 2015
- A list of mandated persons will be maintained

f. Record Keeping
- Concerns are recorded and stored securely (currently in a designated safeguarding file)
- Access limited to appropriate personnel

g. Appointment of Relevant Person
- A Relevant Person has been appointed as the first point of contact regarding this statement

5. Key Roles
- Designated Liaison Person (DLP): *Katie Fiander*
- Relevant Person: *Alastair White*
- Church Leadership (Providers): *Rev. Andrew Gill (Minister) & Merle White (Clerk of Session)*

7. Implementation and Review

The congregation recognises that safeguarding is an ongoing responsibility. We commit to:

- Implementing this Child Safeguarding Statement and the procedures that support it fully
- Reviewing it every 2 years (no later than 24 months from the date of approval), or sooner if there is a material change in service provision or personnel
- Ensuring all leaders and volunteers are aware of their responsibilities
- Displaying this statement publicly and making it available upon request

This statement was formally approved by the Kirk Session on: *8th September 2026.*

It will be reviewed by: 7th September 2028, or sooner if there's a significant change in service provision or personnel.

Signed:



Minister - Rev. Andrew Gill

Tel: 01 565 4081 · Email: minister@standrewschurchblackrock.ie

Key personnel	Telephone	Email
Relevant Person; *Alastair White*	01 565 4081	safeguarding@standrewschurchblackrock.ie
Mandated Person; *Rev. Andrew Gill*	01 565 4081	minister@standrewschurchblackrock.ie
Designated Liaison person; *Katie Fiander*	01 565 4081	DLP@standrewschurchblackrock.ie
PCI Safeguarding	+44 28 9041 7234	safeguarding@presbyterianireland.org
Local Tusla Office	01 215 5700	AM.DSE@tusla.ie
Local Garda Station	01 666 5200	blackrock_ds@garda.ie